



Life



Pain



Mental Health



Disability



Dance



The Last Dance: Abitha P Sunil Rises Through Pain

6 min read · Aug 29, 2024



Pratik Aggarwal

Follow



Listen



Share

Explore Her Story of Enduring Chronic Pain, the Heartbreak of Her Final Dance, and Her Courageous Fight in the Kerala High Court

It all began on a rainy evening in June when I noticed a small, 2 cm edema swelling on my right knee. Surprisingly, it didn't hurt or cause any irritation. The swelling would come and go over a few days, and for weeks, I barely gave it a second thought.

Escalation and Worsening of Symptoms

A few months later, the swelling began to ache, but I dismissed it as minor. Soon, the pain became persistent, disrupting my daily activities. During a *Kalaripayattu* practice, it flared up so intensely that I had to stop. Despite trying Ayurvedic remedies recommended by my *aashan* (master), nothing worked, and the pain forced me to leave the class.

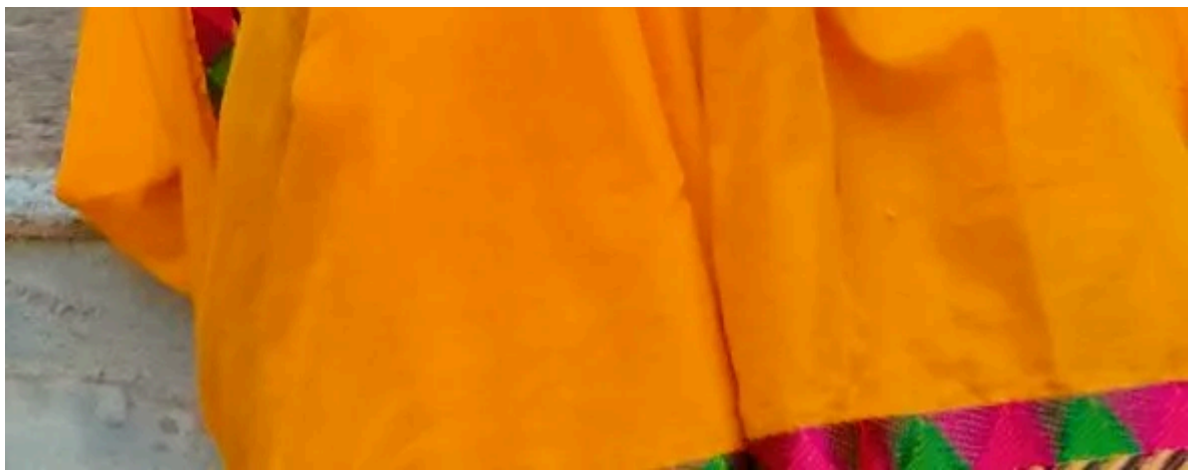
Even after X-rays and MRI scans showed nothing abnormal, the pain spread throughout my right leg. Using a knee cap for support only made the swelling worse.

The Last Dance

I still vividly remember my last dance on December 15, wearing that knee cap. Up until that day, I had danced in almost every college program since joining. But that day marked the first time I had to sit with the audience instead of being on stage.

Watching others dance to the DJ was painful, but what hurt even more was answering the constant question, “Why aren’t you dancing?”





Dance has been a crucial part of my life!

Seeking Answers

By February, both legs were affected, limiting me from even walking short distances. We consulted numerous specialists — physicians, orthopedists, vascular surgeons, dermatologists, rheumatologists, neurologists — but none could what was wrong.

Countless tests, including blood work, X-rays, and scans, all came back normal. With no answers in sight, I was prescribed a variety of painkillers, vitamins, and other medications.

At that time, a neighbor recommended a traditional *vaidya* (doctor) in Calicut. We visited him, and he performed some procedure on the veins in my hands and legs. I felt a bit relieved immediately. He suggested traditional medicines like oil to apply on my head and body, along with internal remedies like kashayam and arishtam.

This experience gave me hope, and I genuinely believed I could return to my normal life.

Return of Symptoms and Misunderstanding

After a brief period of relief, my symptoms gradually returned. By the end of May, my hands, shoulders, and entire body were affected by aching and spreading edema. The exhaustion was overwhelming, making even basic tasks like writing, lifting, and eating a struggle. My confidence eroded as my appearance changed, with bulging eyes and swelling that made me look strange. Some people mistook the

swelling for weight gain, but I knew it was the edema. A neurologist suspected angioedema, but further evaluations ruled it out. Eventually, I was referred to other specialists, and after normal test results and ineffective treatments, I was told that fibromyalgia might be the cause.

Traditional Medicine Journey

I visited many traditional doctors because allopathic doctors dismissed my symptoms as imaginary, which was more painful than the physical discomfort. In August, I underwent Ayurvedic treatment at PNNM Ayurveda Medical College. The doctors and students tried their best to diagnose and treat the problem, but again, nothing seemed to work.

Get Pratik Aggarwal's stories in your inbox

Join Medium for free to get updates from this writer.

Enter your email

Subscribe

☐

Remember me for faster sign in

I took 15 days of treatment followed by 15 days of rest. I missed my college arts fest, sports fest, Onam celebrations, and more, which made me even sadder as it was my final year.

But despite everything, I held on to the hope that this treatment would lead to a good recovery.

Financial, Emotional and Academic Strain

Along with the pain, edema, and muscle weakness, I developed touch sensitivity and shivering. Then, I visited JIPMER, but I still couldn't find an immediate remedy.

Coming from a middle-class family, the expenses of all these treatments were a significant burden. We had spent lakhs of rupees on diagnosing this condition. I began to feel guilty for the financial strain

I was putting on my family, so I started hiding my pain from them and discouraging further diagnostic tests and treatments.

The condition also severely impacted my ability to study, which was particularly devastating as I had always been passionate about law and had worked hard to secure a place in a government college. With five semesters of exams pending due to the COVID-19 pandemic, I began to fear for my academic future. My university informed me that scribe facilities were only available to permanently disabled students.

Fibromyalgia Scribe Support Case

Desperate for support, I discovered that the **Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016** includes benchmark disabilities, and a UGC notification mandates universities to provide scribes for such students. Supported with this information and a medical certificate, I approached my university, but they required a specific format for permanently disabled individuals, necessitating a medical board assessment.

The district hospital initially refused to form a board for fibromyalgia, leading to a deadlock. I then filed a writ of mandamus in the Kerala High Court, **Abitha P Sunil v. State of Kerala**, seeking court intervention. With assistance from Adv. Rebin Vincent Gralan, I presented evidence and documents, resulting in the court directing the hospital to constitute a medical board.

The board assessed my condition, confirming symptoms such as edema and shivering, and issued the required certificate. This enabled me to write four semester exams with scribe assistance.

A New Reality

Adjusting to my new life was incredibly difficult. Suddenly, I found myself at home, unable to do the things I loved — *kalari*, yoga, dance — or even manage simple tasks like brushing my teeth or eating. My confidence crumbled as I struggled with basic activities, relying on my mother and grandmother for help. I was once an extrovert, but I slowly stopped talking to people, disengaged from everything, and began to hate strangers and groups. I uninstalled my social media accounts to stop self-degrading and comparing myself to others. However, this decision helped me improve my mental health significantly.

At just 22, I felt aged and disconnected from my former extroverted self. Social isolation became my norm as I withdrew from friends, uninstalled social media to avoid comparisons, and focused on improving my mental health.

Finding Purpose in the New Normal

Over time, I embraced a more intentional life, focusing on personal growth and meaningful connections. Monthly calls with close friends replaced daily updates, allowing me to cherish shared moments while freeing up time for self-care.

Accepting my new reality, I shifted my focus to what I could achieve, excelling in research, oratory, and public speaking, and finding success in my final year of law studies. Ironically, fibromyalgia became a catalyst for this transformation, teaching me to live with pain while gaining new insights and resilience. Through this journey, I've met others facing similar challenges, discovering that not everyone is crooked — there are good hearts willing to support and walk alongside me.

Despite everything, I've found happiness and new perspectives on life.



Embracing my new reality, I focused on achievements in research, oratory, and law, finding success in my final year of college!

Abitha P Sunil is a lawyer at present and will be an advocate within months now! She loves to work to create a better version of herself, in all aspects of life, physical, mental and spiritual. Even though life made her do things which she hates and restricted do things she loves, she still hates too much rest.

Life

+

Pain

+

Mental Health

+

Disability

+

Dance

+



Follow

Written by Pratik Aggarwal

31 followers · 15 following

Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.
